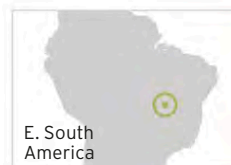


Cathedral of Brasilia

A striking, crownlike Modernist cathedral with a stained-glass ceiling designed for a futuristic city



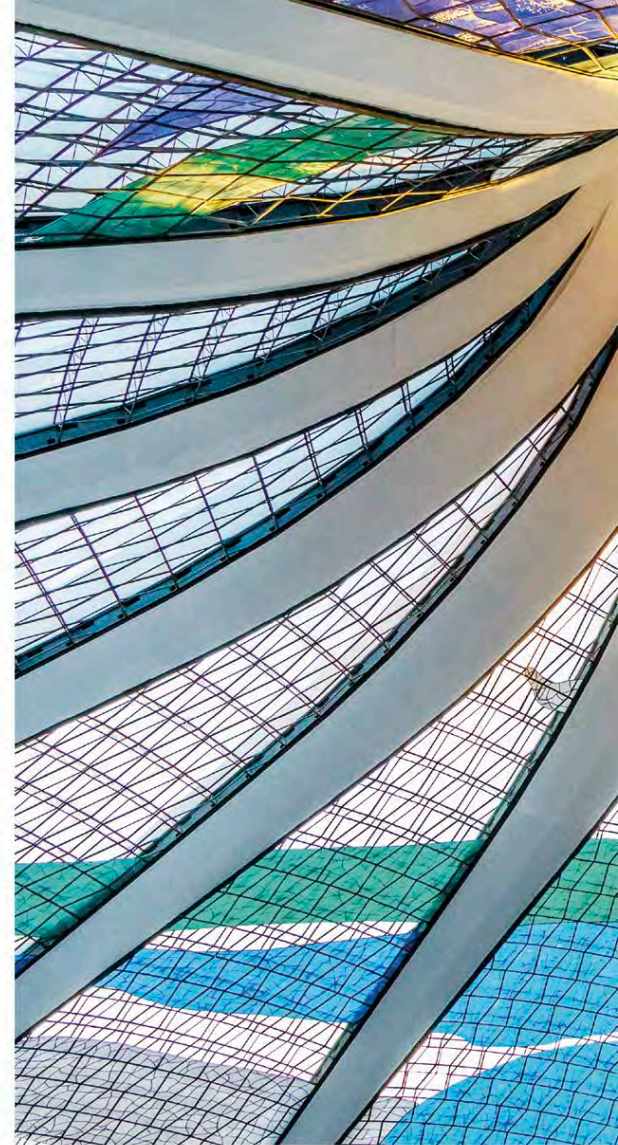
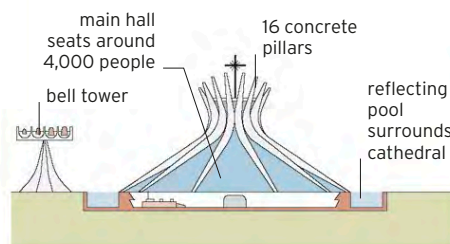
When the decision was made in 1957 to build Brasilia as a new capital city for Brazil, one of the first buildings to be started was its new cathedral. The building was designed by Brazil's most famed Modernist architect, Oscar Niemeyer (1907–2012). Its simple but stunning hyperboloid structure consists of 16 concave concrete columns, each weighing 99 tons (90 tonnes). The cornerstone was laid on September 15, 1958, and the new Metropolitan Cathedral of Our Lady of Aparecida was consecrated on October 21, 1968.

A temple of light

The approach to the cathedral is lined with 10-ft- (3-m-) tall bronze sculptures of the four evangelists: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. To the right is a 66-ft- (20-m-) high bell tower. Visitors to the cathedral emerge through a dark tunnel into a bright, circular hall lit by multicolored stained glass. Three sculpted angels hang from the ceiling.

ABOVE GROUND

Most of the cathedral's floor area is below ground. Only the main roof, 230 ft (70 m) wide and 138 ft (42 m) high; the ovoid roof of the baptistery; and the bell tower are visible above ground. For some observers, the roof represents two hands reaching up to heaven; others see a rendition of the crown of thorns placed on the head of Jesus at his crucifixion.



Central University City Campus of the UNAM

An ensemble of buildings that reflect the energy and aspirations of a rapidly modernizing Mexico



▽ MOSAIC MURAL

A mural called *Historical Representation of Culture* covers the walls of the library building. It is one of the largest continuous mosaics in the world.

Students of the National Autonomous University of Mexico (UNAM) used to attend classes scattered around Mexico City. From 1949 to 1952, a new university was built on one campus, which became the biggest single construction project in Mexico since the Aztec empire (1325–1521). Many of the Modernist buildings incorporate the gardens and volcanic rocks on which the campus stands, but it is the Central Library that stands out for its external decoration.

Giant mosaic

The library is covered with a vast mural designed by the Mexican artist Juan O'Gorman (1905–1982) that extends over 43,000 square ft (4,000 square m). The mural contains millions of mosaics made from colored stones gathered from across Mexico. Its north wall reflects Mexico's pre-Hispanic past, the south wall its colonial history, the east wall the contemporary world, and the west wall the university and modern Mexico. In recognition of this Modernist masterpiece, UNESCO declared the entire campus a World Heritage Site in 2007.

